

UPDATED: March 8th, 2026



AN ERA OF CONFLICT: THE UNIFICATION OF JAPAN

BACKGROUND GUIDE
TRITONMUN XXXI – APRIL 12TH, 2026

MODEL UNITED NATIONS AT UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, SAN DIEGO

BACKGROUND GUIDE TABLE OF CONTENTS

Head Chair Letter.....	2
Crisis Director Letter.....	3
Vice Chair Letter.....	4
Position Paper Guidelines.....	5
Rules of Procedure.....	6
DEI and AI policies.....	7
Key Terms.....	9
Background / Historical Background.....	12
Case Studies.....	14
Character Profiles.....	17
Questions to Consider.....	23
Closing Remarks.....	23
Works Cited.....	25

HEAD CHAIR LETTER

Dear delegates,

Let me start by saying greetings and welcome to the Sengoku Jidai, unification of Japan committee! My name is Troy Pulido, and I will be your head chair for this committee. To start, I'm a first-year Biochemistry major in Eighth College, and I've done MUN since my sophomore year in High School. In terms of MUN, I enjoy Crisis committees and the usual chaos that ensues. With that being said, on the terms of this committee I am deeply invested in Japanese history, especially this time period in particular. I love many of the different aspects of the Sengoku Jidai and hope that from this committee you will derive any sort of enjoyment as I do with the subject. I in particular love hearing about the battles, strategy, and especially the super unique and impactful individuals which can be found throughout the time period. I not only hope for you to enjoy and hopefully learn something about the Sengoku Jidai but will be as invested as I am in the subject. For this committee I am hoping to see a lot of shenanigans, hopefully keeping committee on a serious track (though I am also always open for a little crisis chaos)

On a non-MUN related note, I have many hobbies and love to talk about them. To start, I like to cook and bake, play survival games, and spend too much time watching animated movies. Currently, I love to play *Mewgenics* and *Magic the Gathering* (especially Commander on a weekly basis). As for movies, I love *Redline* and a variety of other animated movies like *The Goofy Movie* and *The Fantastic Mr. Fox*. I look forward to running this committee and getting to see how everything plays out. I hope you will have a fun time and learn something about the Sengoku Jidai! Can't wait to MUN it up and I hope y'all enjoy your time!

Good luck have fun,

Troy Pulido

Chair: The Unification of Japan

tpulido@ucsd.edu

CRISIS DIRECTOR LETTER

Dear delegates,

Welcome to TritonMUN XXXI! My name is Adam Allibhoy, and I have the immense pleasure of serving as your Crisis Director for The Unification of Japan. A little bit about myself: I'm currently a junior majoring in Neurobiology, and this is my tenth year doing MUN. For me, MUN has been an amazing source of experiences, memories, and relationships throughout my life, and I truly couldn't be happier to be here staffing my sixth TritonMUN. In my admittedly boring life outside of MUN, I love soccer and basketball (primarily Arsenal men/women, SD Wave, and the Lakers), marathoning *The Hobbit* and *Lord of the Rings*, and playing video games until sunrise. I'm also an avid cook and baker, and I possess a unique affinity for annoying my roommates with my saxophone.

The Sengoku period of Japan and the Great Unifiers' conquest have fascinated me since I first learned about them in middle school. It never ceases to amaze me how much cultural, technological, and ideological development in the region can be traced back to this conflict and the subsequent establishment of the shogunate. Even so, it is important to emphasize the fact that this was an incredibly bloody period in history, so remember to be diplomatic, aware, and respectful of each other during debate. Please be sure to familiarize yourselves with TritonMUN's policies regarding Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion and use your best judgment throughout the conference. With that being said, I highly encourage you to compete with each other. Amass resources, expand your territory, push the limits of your power and influence. Take advantage of the possibilities and of course, the more details, the better.

If you have any questions or just want to chat, please don't hesitate to reach out! I can't wait to see what you all bring to this committee!

Best,

Adam Allibhoy

Deputy Crisis Director: The Unification of Japan

tritonmun.ucsd@gmail.com

VICE CHAIR LETTER

Dear delegates,

I'm excited to have you all for TritonMUN XXXI and for the Sengoku Jidai! My name is Charlotte Shih, and I'll be your vice chair for this committee. I'm a second-year double major in Environmental Systems: Ecology, Behavior, and Evolution and Literary Arts, with a planned minor in Linguistics. Outside of MUN, I love reading, writing, thrifting, and listening to music. I also love watching shows and movies; I'm unfortunately a huge fan of Star Wars. This is my second year in MUN, but in that time I've traveled twice and staffed several conferences, and I've found myself very fond of crisis committees. I love seeing what I and other delegates can come up with in response to the storyline of the committee; I've seen some incredibly creative solutions to the problems the crisis director has thrown at the committee.

For this committee in particular, I'll echo the sentiments of the chair and crisis director in saying that I'm excited for the kinds of debate and the backroom arcs you'll come up with for this committee. The time period is such a pivotal time, I feel, for the development of Japan's national identity, so much so that we can feel its effects hundreds of years later. I really hope you get the opportunity to immerse yourself in the setting and the figures that we've chosen for this committee, and to come up with solutions that involve not only outright combat but also diplomacy, backhanded deals, and secret alliances. Before the committee starts, please ensure to familiarize yourself with the Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion policies that TritonMUN has in place, as this is a committee regarding war and violence as well as real-life historical figures.

With all that being said, I can't wait to see you in committee. Put your best foot forward, delegates, I know you'll all do great.

Sincerely,

Charlotte Shih

Vice Chair: The Unification of Japan

c5shih@ucsd.edu

POSITION PAPER GUIDELINES

TRITONMUN POSITION PAPER GUIDELINES

- Position Papers are due on **April 3rd at 11:59pm.**
 - Requests for extensions must be sent by the advisor to TritonMUN by **March 22nd.**
- Position Papers must be submitted to the **Google Form** linked here:
 - <https://forms.gle/n68syrNrc7m7PPyAA>
- Format.
 - Papers should be double-spaced in Times New Roman 12 pt. font and include no pictures.
 - At the top of each paper, include your country/person, name, committee, and topic.
 - Required* Sections: Each of these sections should be clearly labeled
 - Background
 - Past Actions by the Committee (if applicable)
 - Position of your Country/Person
 - Possible Solutions

*Some committees may ask for different formatting or an alternative to a position paper altogether, this will be clearly noted in the background guide for that committee

RULES OF PROCEDURE

There will be no alterations to the ROP for this committee outside of what is established within the Tech policy. As this is the case, standard procedure will be used in regards to a crisis committee. There will be a two notebook system with regular crisis updates. You will be expected to write backroom notes, if a problem should arise please bring it up to a staff member.

Given the nature of this committee being a crisis committee and taking place during a time with limited technology, there will be a strict NO TECH policy. This means no usage of laptops, phones or any other device with access to the internet during the course of committee, with the exception of messaging or taking calls for emergencies and such. Notes will be sent through sticky notes or other physical means but absolutely no online messaging during committee. Background guides and position papers will not be allowed to be pulled up online, if access is needed they should be printed prior to committee. Usage of technology will be monitored throughout the committee and unauthorized usage of tech will result in possible disqualification of awards. If you have any questions please direct them towards the chair, vice chair, or DCD, thank you very much.

DEI AND AI POLICIES

Sensitivity & Harassment Policy:

TritonMUN is committed to fostering a healthy environment for diplomacy and dialogue, and upholding standards of diversity, equity, and inclusion for all delegates. Harassment or disruptive behavior of any kind—whether verbal or non-verbal, in or out of committee—is strictly prohibited. All attendees and staffers should be treated with equal respect, and discrimination on the basis of race, color, gender identity, sexual orientation, religion, nationality, ethnicity, or physical/mental disability will not be tolerated. This list is not exhaustive, and should not be treated as such. **Please report any instances of harassment to conference staff, either directly or through the Anonymous Feedback Form.**

In addition, we acknowledge that topics discussed in committee may be politically sensitive, particularly in Specialized and Crisis Committees. While we understand that delegates may be immersed in the action and setting of their committee, delegates must maintain decorum and refrain from inflammatory language and actions, even when doing so may be historically accurate to one's character, group, or country. When drafting crisis directives, delegates should refrain from pursuing any action that explicitly violates human rights, including—but not limited to—enslavement and genocide. **Please refer to your committee's background guide for specific sensitivity statements and guidelines, and direct any questions to the committee's head chair.**

All attendants should observe these policies during the entirety of the conference, even outside formal debate, including opening/closing ceremonies, "FUNMUN", etc. Please note that violation of these policies may result in consequences such as disqualification from awards and contact towards the delegate's Advisor. At TritonMUN, our goal has always been focused on the delegate's abilities to enjoy and have fun in committee. However, in order to truly enjoy TritonMUN, delegates must feel safe in committee, which starts with respecting one another.

Plagiarism & Generative AI Policy:

TritonMUN recognizes that Model United Nations provides a space for aspiring leaders to showcase their work and abilities, and that all delegates wish to be evaluated in a fair and accurate manner. As such, we expect all delegates to perform with integrity and refrain from plagiarizing the work of their peers. This includes—but is not limited to—claiming the work of another delegate as one’s own, including another bloc’s unique clause without prior approval from the original writer, and replacing another’s work with one’s own (i.e. overwriting).

In addition, delegates are strictly prohibited from utilizing generative AI to produce position papers, resolutions, and directives, in part or in their entirety.

Resolution Work Outside of Committee:

TritonMUN wishes that all delegates use their breaks and downtime as intended: to connect, relax, and refresh. While not in committee, delegates are strictly prohibited from working on resolutions and directives. In addition, this means that pre-writing, or preparing resolutions and directives before the start of the conference, is strictly prohibited.

Technology Policy:

Delegates should expect the use of technology to be limited during committee sessions. Instead of having a universal technology policy for TritonMUN, such policies are individualized for each committee and set by their daises. Please refer to each committee’s background guide to understand their technology policies, and direct any questions to the committee’s head chair. Repercussive actions will be taken at the discretion of the head chair.

KEY TERMS

- Daimyō
 - Powerful and influential Japanese lords, typically vassals of the shogun. Defined through their control over large areas of lands and its peoples. Typically, they commanded samurai armies, with leadership of their armies and land being passed down heretically. At the time of 1560, due to political discourse, many of the Daimyō were independent of the Shogun.
- Shogun
 - The centralized military leader of Japan, passed down from generation to generation through the same family. Though the emperor does exist due to the weakness and actual power of the emperor, the Shogun is essentially the leader of Japan. At the time of 1560, the Shogun had devolved into a position controlled externally and was nothing more than a figurehead who had little to no actual power, this being the Ashikaga shogunate.
- shi-nō-kō-shō system
 - Though not officially put into place until the 1600s, the system still refers to the developing caste system that separated roles of individuals in Japanese society. From the top to the bottom were warriors and rulers, farmers, artisans, and finally the lowest merchants. During the time of this committee, this system was based more so on merit and influence rather than heredity, thus those in the merchant class could often still be considered in the highest class of rulers based on ability and merit.
- Ashigaru

The light-weight common foot soldiers often being farmers conscripted into battle, serving their respected samurai. Making up a majority of armies and being lightly armored and armed with weapons such as spears, bows, and in some cases firearms.
- Samurai
 - The military caste of Japan, typically being highly skilled and trained warriors being retainers to a respective Daimyō. Essentially Samurai were the elites

making up Daimyō's army making up a much smaller percentage of armies though playing just a large role.

- Kumi
 - Groups of small organized and specialized troops in an army, each using one particular type of weapon. They would utilize weapons such as pikes, arquebuses, and bows.
- Koku system
 - The way used to assess the prosperity of a region and in turn taxes, stipends for samurai, and wealth of the Daimyō who controlled the region. This was entirely based around how much rice a region could produce, one koku being equivalent to 180 liters/150 kg of rice being able to be produced. Higher values meaning more power and thus higher taxes
- Arquebus
 - A portable matchlock and smoothbore firearm introduced by the Portuguese and reverse-engineered in 1543. The arquebus could only be used in the hundreds and still see a huge difference in effectiveness in combat.
- Sonae
 - Units of troops consistent of anywhere between 300 to 800+ troops loyal to a specific Daimyō. Each functioned as an independent unit however led by a retainer to the Daimyō and consisting of a variety of Kumi, samurai, and cavalry.
- Clans
 - Independent military units typically led by a singular family with leadership (being the Daimyō) being passed down from generation to generation. These units would lead armies following the will of the current Daimyō they follow. The structure was defined by the head being the Daimyō and beneath them would be Samurai retainers who would typically be family, heirs, and enemies who submitted to the Daimyō (each would typically lead a Sonae).
- Jizamurai
 - Translating to samurai of the land, these were the individuals who bridged the gap between the leading and farming class. These individuals functioned as smaller

local leaders and landowners. They serve a crucial role in control of a region as each holds some sort of influence over a given piece of land.

- Yamashiro province
 - The province which contained the capital of Japan at the time. This province was extremely important being centralized and control of this province translating into the control over the shogun and in turn Japan. Thus control over this province was critical to any Daimyō hoping to lead the country, hence the province being defined by constant conflict and chaos.
- Hirajiro/yamajiro
 - Different types of castles or fortresses built upon flatlands or mountains respectively. Each of these served as critical tactical points improving trade logistics, and protection over regions. In short these castles were essential pieces of logistics and military operations, determining effective control over a region.
- Tanada
 - Agricultural terraces which were usually dedicated towards the growth of rice. These served an imperative role in the prosperity of a region and being able to feed an army. These terraces also directly influenced the Koku of a region and thus prosperity. Essentially the more Tanada a region had the more prosperous it typically was.
- Bunkokuhō
 - Domain or provincial laws enacted by an individual region's Daimyō. Put in place after the fall of the Ashikaga shogunate, they are individualized to every region based on the whims of their Daimyō. They differed greatly ranging from laws to control farmers or retainers, to taxes and whole law systems unique to regions controlled by that Daimyō.

AN ERA OF CONFLICT: THE UNIFICATION OF JAPAN

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND

In 1467, the Ōnin War began, resulting in the collapse of the power of the Ashikaga shogunate, meaning that there was no longer a shogun and thus central organization of military power, transforming the shogunate into a powerless figurehead. Ultimately, this split the empire into regions controlled by Daimyō whom the shogunate lost control of as a result of the war. Normally, this would not be a problem, however given the caste system forming in Japan at the time, the shi-nō-kō-shō system, Daimyō now essentially became regional Lords whose word was law (known as Bunkokuho). The Ōnin War would set the tone for the years coming up to 1560, seeing hundreds of wars and thousands more injured or killed due to the fracturing of the nation. During this time period, many would rise to prominence just to as quickly lose it all. Though at the time, the shi-nō-kō-shō system would become a widely accepted system, this era saw unprecedented mobility through the system with many of those in lower castes such as farmers or merchants being able to rise to become powerful and notable warriors and rulers.

Given the enticing opportunity of unifying and leading Japan, many would consolidate power in their home and surrounding regions, often clashing with neighboring Daimyō. This resulted in years of small territorial wars in the aims of expanding territory and gaining an upper hand in the ultimate struggle of ruling Japan. During this time, warfare was heavily reliant on cavalry, archery, and pikes as counters to cavalry, with typically the victor being decided through sheer numbers. During these years, warfare would remain relatively stagnant until the introduction of guns in 1543 on the island of Tanegashima through Portuguese traders (Goldman). The guns from the supposedly wrecked and crashed Portuguese ship would be reverse-engineered and produced across the island. The introduction of guns into warfare was slow though impactful, slowly evolving warfare from an emphasis on archers to troops armed with arquebuses. However, firearms would not be the only change, as six years later with the arrival of Francis Xavier came the introduction of Christianity into Japan (“History of Christianity in Japan”). Christianity did not stand simply as a new rival religion to the dominant Shinto-Buddhist religion, rather alongside this the introduction of Christianity instilled fear of an inevitable European conquest into many at the time.

Wars would rage on without there being a clear candidate for unifying Japan, with the shogunate continuing to be simply a puppet and figurehead. During this time there would be much political discourse within the capital with an internal struggle breaking out resulting in the upheaval of the Ashikaga shogunate. The current shogun Ashikaga Yoshiteru would not truly return until around 1559, spending nine years in exile (Ronald K). With regions being won and lost at a whim, one Daimyō stood out, Imagawa Yoshimoto, who in the summer of 1560 formed an unprecedented three-way alliance with the powerful Takeda and Hōjō clans. With this alliance securing his rear, Yoshimoto amassed an army of anywhere between 25,000 to 40,000 troops beginning his march to the capital to secure his control over the capital and all the land inbetween. Between Yoshimoto and the capital stood the land controlled by the Oda clan, however Yoshimoto was not worried due to his numbers advantage and the fear his newly amassed army caused. After many crushing victories against the Oda clan, it seemed almost certain of Yoshimoto's control over the capital and thus leading of the country. However, this would come to change after Oda Nobunaga led a surprise attack against the Imagawa forces whilst they were resting at Dengakuhazama Gorge. The attack resulted in the death of Imagawa Yoshimoto and the dissolution of his army to a point where they could not recover. This upset secured Nobunaga the Owari province once more and further plunged Japan into a state of chaos with no clear candidate for ruling the country. Alongside this chaos emerged a newly determined Nobunaga, and similarly many other Daimyo now making plans to rule Japan.

CASE STUDIES

Battle of Okehazama

A pivotal battle in the Sengoku Jidai period which solidified Oda Nobunaga as a prominent Daimyo and highlighted the importance of tactics and knowledge in battle. The battle started due to the powerful Daimyo Imagawa Yoshimoto securing his Eastern border through the marriages of his sister and son into the powerful Takeda and Hōjō clans respectively (“The Battle of Okehazama”). With his two biggest rivals in a three-way alliance, Imagawa Yoshimoto decided it was the best time to mobilize his army of at least 25,000 in Kyoto and overthrow the Ashikaga shogunate. Between him and Kyoto stood the Oda-controlled Owari province and Oda forces whom Yoshimoto outnumbered more than several times. Expecting an easy victory, Yoshimoto marched upon the Owari province.

As expected, the Imagawa forces saw little to no difficulty throughout their campaign. With several fortresses and key strategic points falling under Yoshimoto’s control and the dwindling morale and resources of the Oda forces, Yoshimoto’s victory was almost certain. Thus with victory in sight, the Imagawa forces on their way to Odaka castle decided to rest and celebrate their recent victories at Okehazamayama, specifically in the Dengakuhazama gorge. Meanwhile, the battered Oda forces numbering around 2,000 led by Oda Nobunaga decided that instead of simply attempting to defend a fortress and inevitably lose, they would lead a direct assault upon the Imagawa forces. Recognizing their numbers disadvantage, Nobunaga played into their strengths being their knowledge of Dengakuhazama gorge and a misdirection in tactics. To further their element of surprise, Oda forces raised fake banners and planted decoys at Zensho-ji Fort confusing Yoshimoto’s reconnaissance. Finally under the cover of a violent rainstorm, the Oda forces began their attack on Imagawa forces by utilizing passages through mountains and valleys. Given the combined factors of Imagawa forces celebrating, a misinformed army, and the Oda forces' unexpected entrance into the gorge the Imagawa forces were taken completely off guard, barely being able to raise a defense. The sudden attack and death of Imagawa Yoshimoto by Mouri Shinsuke led to the retreat of Imagawa forces and complete victory for the Oda Nobunaga (“About the Battle of Okehazama”). Afterwards, Oda forces would practically eliminate most of the higher powers of the Imagawa forces with the rest submitting to Nobunaga.

With the death of Imagawa Yoshimoto and the destruction of his army there came several outcomes. First was the end of the alliance between the rival clans of Imagawa, Takeda, and Hōjō. The end of this alliance, meant a rocky and uneasy relationship between the Takeda and Hōjō clans. This once again locked prominent Daimyo in a stalemate. Furthermore, alongside the weakening of the Imagawa was the release of Matsudaira Motoyasu later known as Tokugawa Ieyasu, who would proceed to become an independent Daimyo securing the Mikawa province and making a name for himself given his political ability (“Ieyasu and the Unification of Mikawa”). Finally was the unexpected victory of the Oda forces over Yoshimoto. This total victory gave Nobunaga the momentum to retake his home province of Owari, and national recognition as a major Daimyo (Kimball). In short, the Battle of Okehazama was a major turning point in the Sengoku Jidai which showcased the importance of tactics over numbers, and just how rapidly situations could change during the Sengoku Jidai.

Ōnin War

By 1467, the power of the Ashikaga shogunate had declined to a point of weakness that a simple succession issue would lead to chaos. The shogunate lost power due to consolidating within the capital and appointing many individuals control over land outside the capital. Additionally, Ashikaga Yoshimasa, the shogun at the time, was considered a weak leader who prioritized art and culture, resulting in the ensuing succession. Thus, when a dispute between his brother and own son started over who would succeed Yoshimasa, the capital fell into chaos. The conflict became a problem however when Yamana Sōzen and his son-in-law, Hosokawa Katsumoto, who controlled armies of 160,000 and 110,000 respectively, sided with differing factions in the succession dispute (Turnbull). The actual fighting started due to the Hosokawa attacking one of the mansions of a Yamana general, utilizing swords, arrows, and fire, which set the stage for the conflict. Each side would be protecting and backing one of the possible next Shogun in their respective mansions in the capital. This would lead to an 11-year conflict that only evolved as time went on, known as the Ōnin War.

Though the Ōnin War started with a small political dispute, it would ultimately have lasting effects on the capital, the political system of Japan, and warfare, and led to the conditions seen in the Sengoku Jidai. As previously stated, swords, arrows, and fire were used, however as time progressed, weapons would not just be limited to these. Eventually, due to contact with

China, weapons such as exploding arrows and fire spears started appearing. The combined usage of fire alongside these weapons would see the capital devastated from the various fires, street warfare, and eventually looters who pillaged the city (Matthew). Ultimately, this left the once vibrant and culturally rich Kyōto nothing more than charred ruins. As many of those in the centralized government lived and operated out of the capital, this would leave the country without a real government, with leadership instead falling to those appointed land prior to the Ōnin War.

The Ōnin War was the start of the Sengoku Jidai and highlighted several key factors that would be prevalent throughout the era, mainly revolving around the actual power of the shogunate and thus a centralized government. As seen from the beginning of the conflict, the title of Shogun held enough power to start an 11-year-long war which saw the destruction of Kyōto and the lives of those who lived in and around the city. Furthermore, the Ōnin War is the whole reason for the Sengoku Jidai starting to showcase the ambitions of the Daimyo and the lengths many were willing to go in order to control the military-based government of Japan. The final factor is the recurring theme of control over the shogunate and capital to rule Japan, versus the leadership falling to the in many cases more capable Daimyo. In short, the Ōnin War not only started the Sengoku Jidai but remained relevant throughout the years of conflicts for these reasons, and forms of warfare.

CHARACTER PROFILES

Oda Nobunaga

A great warrior, politician, and strategic genius. At the time of 1560, Nobunaga was one of the most prominent Daimyō, after his victory over Imagawa Yoshimoto (who was expected to become the next shogun). As of this time, Nobunaga really only controls the Owari region though he is not content with simply securing his region's borders. Nobunaga uniquely incorporates firearms and unique strategies into warfare which has led to his overwhelming victories and his enemies fearing him. Furthermore, he has gained a lot of momentum and prominence after his surprising victory over Imagawa Yoshimoto. Nobunaga ultimately aims to unify Japan through force and bring about a new era.

Maeda Toshimasu

Also known as Maeda Keiji and often referred to as the greatest samurai gangster. Toshimasu was a legendary warrior known for his unparalleled strength and size. Toshimasu was extremely close with his loyal and one-of-a-kind horse, Matsukaze, with their bond and strength being known across Japan. Though not in a major position of leadership, Toshimasu remains a legendary warrior who was highly educated, independent, and culturally knowledgeable. Toshimasu does not control land outside of Noto province, though he has potential to govern much more. Toshimasu values personal freedom and expression more than anything else with politics not being a priority for him.

Takeda Shingen

Known as the Tiger of Kai, Shingen is a master tactician who was highly educated and highly renowned for his strategy which at the time not many could truly compare to. As of 1560, Shingen controlled his home province of Kai, Shinano province, and parts of the Kozuke Province. Shingen was known for his knowledge of espionage, communication, and his devastating cavalry-based strategies. Shingen not only is a genius tactician but also a master of civil administration and infrastructure, which would see regions under his control having actual fair laws and well-built infrastructure. Like many, Shingen wishes to unify Japan, wanting to bring order back to the shogunate and Japan in general.

Uesugi Kenshin

The Dragon of Echigo, Kenshin was a genius strategist whose skill in tactics were said to only be rivaled by Takeda Shingen. Kenshin controls four main locations: his main province of Echigo, Kantō Region, parts of the Kōzuke Province, and Northern Shinano. However, unlike others, Daimyō Kenshin has little to no ambition in terms of expanding his territory, rather often only involving himself in conflicts for honorable or moral reasons. Kenshin was not only known for his skill in strategy but also a skillful administrator, which ultimately saw a higher standard of living in his regions. Finally, Kenshin was considered a great figure in the eyes of Buddhists, often being called the incarnation of the Buddhist god of war Bishamonten.

Tokugawa Ieyasu

Heir to the Matsudaira clan and a master politician known for his patience and ability to navigate the political world of Japan. Though as of now he only controls his home province of Mikawa, he has many allies and loyal retainers whom he can call upon. One such as Hattori Hanzo, an extremely talented ninja, samurai and leader of the Iga ninja. Ieyasu is known for his patience and political skill, often not taking risks and instead waiting for the right time to make a move. Through his political skill, he is easily able to make alliances with many and ultimately lead to his uncanny ability to survive dire situations. After his recent release from the Imagawa clan, his opportunities are endless, seeing how quickly he was able to unify his home province. Ieyasu aimed to unify Japan and, in turn, create a long-lasting stabilized government, securing his family's legacy.

Hōjō Ujiyasu

A master of defensive warfare and abnormal battle tactics, Ujiyasu, also known as Lion of Sagami, was a legendary figure standing among other great Daimyō such as Takeda Shingen and Uesugi Kenshin. Ujiyasu controls five provinces: Sagami, Izu, Musashi, Shimōsa, and Kazusa, though is often involved in conflict resulting in constant defensive battles. Ujiyasu not only was well-versed in combat but also knowledgeable in diplomacy, governance, and culture, implementing the Hōjō Regulations, and making alliances and truces to benefit himself. Ujiyasu did not have much of the same ambition as the other Daimyō, rather than wishing to expand and unify Japan Ujiyasu preferred stability and prosperity of regions he already controlled.

Akechi Mitsuhide

Mitsuhide stands out among many others through having a very obscure and minor background, however, this did not stop his ability to rapidly gain power in a relatively short timespan. Mitsuhide was a cunning and extremely intelligent samurai known for his deep intellectual and cultural knowledge, and ability in governance and regional administration. Although Mitsuhide currently controls only the Tanba Province and parts of Omi Province, he should not be underestimated as these regions are a part of central Japan and thus play a major factor in deciding the shogun. Mitsuhide strives for a peaceful and stable Japan, wanting to end the chaotic times of the Sengoku Jidai, backing the traditional Ashikaga shogunate, and restoring their power.

Ōtomo Sōrin

The progressive Daimyō, Sōrin was known for adopting several foreign policies and technologies into his controlled provinces. Known for being one of the only Daimyō who converted to Catholicism, Sōrin not only encouraged Christianity but also adopted many Western technologies into his territories, hoping in the end to see a Christian kingdom. His progressiveness also led to an openness to international trade, which led to decent relations with foreign powers and the usage of firearms in his own military. After the battle of Okehazama, Sōrin mainly controlled Bungo, Buzen, Chikuzen, and Chikugo, though had influence in Higo, Hizen, and Iyo, controlling a good chunk of northern Japan. Sōrin wanted to see a unified Christian Japan, which would see many European principles governing it, alongside foreign trade.

Toyotomi Hideyoshi

Advancing from being a simple farmer to a capable politician, strategist, and warrior, Hideyoshi is one of the most unique of the era. Even though he did not control much territory after 1560, outside of fortresses like Nagahama Castle, which was built in a major transport hub, Hideyoshi makes up for this through his numerous other skills. Hideyoshi is an expert politician known for his ability to turn even the most loyal retainers against their lords. Furthermore, Hideyoshi was also known for his ability in siege warfare and rapid logistic response. Hideyoshi aims for a unified Japan strong enough to conquer foreign powers and expand borders, whilst being unable to challenge his authority.

Mōri Motonari

Coming from relatively humble origins, Mōri Motonari has risen to prominence as a very powerful daimyō. Originally the second in line to the Mōri samurai family, the death of Motonari's older brother allowed him to secure power in the family, and he soon launched conquests against several other families to eventually seize control over a large swath of territory across 10 different provinces. By 1560, Motonari was renowned for his cunning and strategic brilliance, and his three sons were loyal and similarly talented leaders within their father's territory. Beyond his military capabilities, Motonari was also an exceptionally talented diplomat and poet, and he is one of the few daimyō who could reasonably stand a chance against Oda Nobunaga's expansionism.

Kobayakawa Takakage

The third and youngest of Mōri Motonari's sons was originally born Tokujumaru before eventually becoming heir to the Kobayakawa family, taking the name Takakage. When he first took power, the Kobayakawa family was divided into two sects, but his marriage in 1551 helped to bridge this rift, securing him at its head. Although relatively untested as an independent leader and general, he served under his father as a naval commander and played a significant role in his victory in the Battle of Miyajima in 1555, which ultimately allowed the family to consolidate much of their territories. Now, he's hungry to prove himself and begin his own pursuits beyond working with his father.

Kennyō

Kennyō Kōsa is one of the main leaders of the Ikko-Ikki, a collection of radical Hōgan-ji Buddhist fanatics. The group was originally founded as a religious sect, but over the years, it has become immensely popular among peasants and gained a significant following. Now based in the Ishiyama Hōgan-ji fortress, the Ikko-Ikki has allies in clans and groups across the island, such as clan Asakura and the Ashikaga shogunate. However, its growing military force has drawn the attention of warlords seeking to eliminate potential threats to their rule. While Kennyō and his forces of warrior monks have largely kept to themselves recently, they have the potential to begin expanding their territory should they choose to do so.

Chōsokabe Motochika

Based in his stronghold of Oko Castle, Chōsokabe Motochika is the leader of the Chōsokabe clan and has steadily been on the rise. In May 1560, he recently won one of his first battles as a leader in the Battle of Tonomoto Nagahama, claiming Nagahama Castle alongside his father, Kunichika. Until recently, there have been many questions as to whether or not he can serve as an effective wartime leader, but the young daimyō has finally managed to gain some momentum coming into the impending conflict. Now controlling much of Shikoku, Motochika could be a valuable ally for any warlords seeking to mount an offensive, assuming that he doesn't seek to begin a conquest of his own on the mainland.

Ashikaga Yoshiteru

As Shogun of the Ashikaga shogunate, Ashikaga Yoshiteru rules the remains of what was, at one point, one of Japan's strongest powers. However, the remains of the shogunate have since declined to a shadow of its former self, with Yoshiteru sequestering himself in Shōryūji Castle in the small Yamashiro Province. However, a new opportunity has presented itself to Yoshiteru, as he has recently approved the presence of Father Gaspar Vilela, a Portuguese priest and missionary. While he has not actively provided aid for any of his missions, Yoshiteru has thus proved himself a potential ally for Portugal by allowing Vilela to continue his work. So though his military may currently be diminished, Yoshiteru's political potential is far from obsolete.

Miyoshi Nagayoshi

Miyoshi Nagayoshi has fought long and hard to grow his clan to new heights. Nagayoshi has taken his clan from a very small territory to now controlling the majority of the Kinai region, including Kyoto itself. Nagayoshi has proven himself a highly capable military strategist and politician, weathering sieges and forming alliances to maximize his power with the goal of unifying Japan under his rule. While his power is not absolute, he has taken enough steps to secure important political alliances and protection from the prospect of an uprising, especially with the Muromachi shogunate, which remains present in Kyoto under Nagayoshi's rule. Recently, he moved his base of operations to Iimoriyama Castle in the mountains of Osaka, highly fortified and ready for whatever conflict is to come.

Amago Haruhisa

Amago Haruhisa took over as daimyō and head of the Amago clan following the retirement of his grandfather. As part of the territory he took over, he rallied his military forces throughout the San'in region to expand his territory into the Sanyo province, as well. His most recent conquest came against the Shingu clan, led by his uncle, Amago Kunihisa, and he absorbed the remnants into his own forces. Haruhisa is a ruthless warrior and keen strategist seeking to strengthen his forces and secure his political power. However, expansion requires funds, and Haruhisa has had his eye on the Omori Silver Mine for some time now. If his past is any indication, he will not hesitate to make moves to expand.

Honda Tadakatsu

As one of the youngest warriors of his time, Honda Tadakatsu has already established himself as a samurai prodigy. The son of Honda Tadamasa and heir to the Honda clan, he has a clear path laid out for him: continue serving with his father, learn to govern the land, and eventually succeed him when the time comes. Currently, the Honda clan has committed itself to serving Tokugawa Ieyasu and his mission, and so far, their interests have been aligned in seeking security through expansion. However, Tadakatsu is already proving himself a talented general and warrior, and it may only be a matter of time before he decides to set out on his own with his loyal clan beside him.

Asakura Yoshikage

Unlike many of the other daimyō of his time, Asakura Yoshikage has little public interest in ruthlessly expanding his territory. As head of the Asakura clan, he has sought to ensure peace and prosperity from the beginning, ending the feud between his people and the Ikko-Ikki as soon as he came to power. He has since chosen to serve as a diplomatic and political leader from his home in Ichijōdani Castle. Yoshikage's reign over the Echizen province has been characterized by rapid social and cultural development, and his military leaders and generals have done well to keep his reign secure. One of his next big goals is to expand trade, and he largely opposes expansion, but he will do what it takes to keep his people safe.

QUESTIONS TO CONSIDER

1. Should the old Ashikaga shogunate be reinstated and given power again, or is another form of government or leadership such as the Daimyō necessary given Japan's evolving state?
2. Who should control portions of land in Japan, should it continue to be Daimyō, the people, or a centralized government?
3. Should Bunkokuhō and tax systems still be kept the same?
4. Given the nature of how much Japan's social hierarchy evolved during the Sengoku Jidai, what should happen to the strict shi-nō-kō-shō system?
5. Should the Nation expand outwards or adopt a more isolationist stance?
6. How should Japan adapt given external powers' influence and trade?

CLOSING REMARKS

In summary, it should be clear just how chaotic the Sengoku Jidai was, most importantly, how pivotal a time the committee takes place, being a little after the battle of Okehazama. Ever since the Ōnin War, which saw the dissolution of the Ashikaga shogunate, Japan has been in a state of political disarray and has been embroiled in a centuries-long conflict. To the recent battle of Okehazama, which saw a major upset and turning point in who would unify Japan, kickstarting the situation presented in the committee. It could be easily said that at this time, there are many factors that can play a huge role in unifying Japan, from guns to many talented and unique individuals. Furthermore, Japan was in a large state of disarray and very susceptible to change, leading to a very liquid state where anything could be enacted or changed. Thus, in an overall sense, this time period was the best time for anyone to make a play and achieve their goals, securing their legacy. In short, it should be clear that any singular character in this committee can make a massive impact on the direction of Japan and influence change in the country (in the committee, of course), and as such, we are hoping to see this.

As for characters in the committee themselves, staying as close to your character as possible would be best as many are taking action and doing whatever it takes to achieve their goals. Thus, for the committee to run smoothly, do whatever it takes and utilize not only your

front room political skills but also the back room. Furthermore, recognize that each character has unique strengths and qualities to help in this regard; feel free to utilize them, even those found beyond the background guide, given they are historically accurate. Given the nature of the committee, your backroom actions will be weighed heavily and play a major role in deciding the direction of the committee, so ensure that your notes are detailed and impactful. Finally, do not just focus solely on one aspect, whether that is political, military, or infrastructure; this committee is multifaceted and there are many possible outcomes, so expect things to change often.

Finally, delegates, you have hopefully learned something about the Sengoku Jidai, and hopefully, the committee has piqued your interest in the subject. Just remember to ultimately have fun and enjoy yourself in the committee. Can't wait for all of you during the conference, and good luck!

WORKS CITED

- “About the Battle of Okehazama.” *Take the Leading Role in the Movie “The Battle of Okehazama”!*, <https://nobunaga.okehazama.net/en/about-en/>. Accessed 22 Feb. 2026.
- “Amako Haruhisa.” *Kotobank*, DIGITALIO, 2026, kotobank.jp/word/%E5%B0%BC%E5%AD%90%E6%99%B4%E4%B9%85-27147. Accessed 2026.
- “Ashikaga Yoshiteru (1536-1565).” *Japan Reference*, 11 Aug. 2025, jref.com/articles/ashikaga-yoshiteru-1536-1565.898/.
- Cezary Jan Strusiewicz. “Honda Tadakatsu: The Indestructible Samurai.” *Tokyo Weekender*, 24 July 2025, www.tokyoweekender.com/art_and_culture/history/honda-tadakatsu-the-indestructible-samurai/.
- Cryns, Frederik. “Short Biography of Miyoshi Nagayoshi (2) Consolidating Power.” *Frederikcryns.com*, 29 Apr. 2024, frederikcryns.com/blog/short-biography-of-miyoshi-nagayoshi---consolidating-power.
- “Documents of the Chosokabe Clan Discovered and on Display from the 11th at Yamauchi Family Museum.” *The Asahi Shimbun*, 11 Dec. 2010, web.archive.org/web/20110929173344/mytown.asahi.com/areanews/kochi/OSK201012100141.html.
- Goldman, Eli. “The Impact of Pikes and Guns in Sengoku-Period Japan.” *Student Scholarship*, Jan. 2020, <https://digitalcommons.denison.edu/studentscholarship/29>.
- “History of Christianity in Japan.” *OMF International*, OMF Japan, 15 June 2021, <https://omf.org/history-of-christianity-in-japan/>.

- “Ieyasu and the Unification of Mikawa.” *Saga of the Samurai Frontpage*, 21 Sept. 2013,
<https://www.sagaofthesamurai.no/sengoku-jidai/ieyasu-unification-mikawa/>.
- Jan Strusiewicz, Cezary. “Mori Motonari: Japan’s Beggar Prince Who Conquered the Island of God.” *Tokyo Weekender*, 30 June 2025,
www.tokyoweekender.com/art_and_culture/history/mori-motonari-japans-beggar-prince/.
- Kimball, Donny. “Below the Bar.” *A Different Side of Japan*, 3 Sept. 2020,
<https://donnykimball.com/battle-of-okehazama-c0ac3df0ddf1>.
- Matthew, Penney. “Ōnin War | History | Research Starters | EBSCO Research.” *EBSCO*,
<https://www.ebsco.com>. Accessed 24 Feb. 2026.
- “Miyoshi.” *Kotobank*, DIGITALIO, 2026,
kotobank.jp/word/%E4%B8%89%E5%A5%BD%E9%95%B7%E6%85%B6-16803.
- “Mōri Motonari.” *Japan Reference*, 5 Apr. 2013, jref.com/articles/m%C5%8Dri-motonari.230/.
- Ronald K, Frank. “Battle of Okehazama | History | Research Starters | EBSCO Research.”
EBSCO, 2022, <https://www.ebsco.com>.
- Sansom, George. *A History of Japan, 1334-1615*. Stanford University Press, 1 June 1961.
- Sengoku Jidai: Japan’s Warring States Period - Gettysburg National Military Park (U.S. National Park Service)*. National Park Service,
<https://www.nps.gov/gett/learn/historyculture/sengoku-jidai.htm>. Accessed 16 Feb. 2026.
- “Takakage.” *Kotobank*, DIGITALIO, 2026,
kotobank.jp/word/%E5%B0%8F%E6%97%A9%E5%B7%9D%E9%9A%86%E6%99%AF-16258. Accessed 1 Mar. 2026.

“The Battle of Okehazama.” *Nagoya International Center*,

<https://www.nic-nagoya.or.jp/en/news-events/course/2020/06220000.html>. Accessed 22 Feb. 2026.

The Life of Warlord Chosokabe Motochika. Samurai History & Culture Japan, 11 July 2025, samuraihistoryculture.substack.com/p/the-life-of-warlord-chosokabe-motochika.

Turnbull, Stephen. “Ōnin War.” *Britannica*, Encyclopedia Britannica, Nov. 2024, <https://www.britannica.com/event/Onin-War>.
